Cricket is such a time-consuming game. Retirement, for many players, is challenging because the game leaves a void. We are unaccustomed to having a lot of downtime. It is not like a rugby or football player, who trains between two games a week. Our respite tends to come during matches, when the opposition is in the field, but even then, the variables of form preoccupy the mind.

I'm not qualified to talk about the intricacies of depression, or provide a clinical analysis of the condition, but any sport forces you into a negative space quite a lot of the time, because you invariably fail. Athletes in all disciplines have been more forthcoming about the strain in recent years; cricket has become more open in the decade or so since Marcus Trescothick laid himself bare.

In no particular order, Andrew Flintoff, Monty Panesar, Sarah Taylor, Graeme Fowler, Michael Yardy, Steve Davies, Graham Thorpe, Steve Harmison, Tim Ambrose and Iain O'Brien have all spoken about mental-health issues. In itself that's unsurprising, since research has suggested that, on average, around 15 per cent of elite athletes suffer similarly.

High achievers, high stakes, high pressure.

I wouldn't want to dwell on individuals, because that is personal territory and involves specialist knowledge. My issues were not of that magnitude, though when I was really struggling for runs, and dealing with the fallout from the Kevin Pietersen affair, I was not in a good place. I rarely argue with Alice, since we are not that type of couple, but I was taking out some of the pressure on her.

I felt alone, exposed. In that state of mind, it is easy to forget that strain also affects those closest to you. The ECB organize a box for players' families, and offer a crèche, but the elephant in the room is individual form. There is always someone whose partner is under pressure. Conversely, there is also someone whose loved one is absolutely flying, relishing life, scoring runs or taking wickets. The extremes of concern and joy make things complicated when they are expressed in close proximity.

It doesn't matter, in a way, that the wheel tends to turn. No one is a media darling for ever. Anyone who cannot contribute consistently is liable to fade away. Our families live our cricket, and deal with the consequences, without direct influence on the outcome. That's difficult when, understandably enough, they identify with your dreams, and are desperate for you to do well.